



Richard M Stallman, founder, GNU Project and Free Software Foundation

## RMS vs proprietary software, Linux and open source

**Q** Please talk about your journey with Free and Open Source Software.

Well, actually it's not open source—please don't connect me with that. I disagree with that. In fact, open source was started specifically to reject the ideas that I stand for. My journey is about free, *swatantra* and *mukt* software. Before I started the Free Software Movement, I lived in a free software community, so I knew from experience that free software was a good way of life—I was not just imagining it. That

“Any government that tells people to teach proprietary software is essentially delivering the country into the hands of a company,”

When it comes to propagating Free Software, there can be no one as assertive as RMS (as **Richard M Stallman** is fondly known). Proprietary software, or anything that hampers freedom, is totally unacceptable to him. But before you meet him, make sure you are aware of all that he strongly believes in, or you could be caught on the wrong foot. Don't utter the words Linux or Open Source in front of him—RMS doesn't believe in them! He walks on the GNU/Linux and Free Software path.

On a recent visit to India, RMS spoke to **Diksha P Gupta** of **LFY Bureau** exclusively about his ideas on freedom, Android, Steve Jobs, Facebook and the Indian Free Software community. Read on...

was when I was working at the MIT Artificial Intelligence lab in the 1970s. The lab was part of a larger free software community. We shared software around, and all the software we used, with very rare exceptions, was free software. A lot of it had been written by us. I thought it good. It also meant that you could fix anything that bothered you.

At the beginning, in 1971, when I was hired by the lab, free software was not unusual. Lots of operating systems were free. But, by the end of the 1970s, free software had become rare. Proprietary software was the norm everywhere—and then in the early 80s, our community died, and I was dropped into the proprietary world. In contrast with the free software way